



Beijing 2008 **BOXING**

Flexing their MUSC

■ By Sharda Ugra in Beijing

If you can remember only one thing about India's boxers at the 2008 Olympics, remember a man called Babbi. It doesn't matter that Babbi wasn't even there. He was busy earning his living in Patiala, washing clothes. For his entire working life, Babbi has knocked on doors at the National Institute of Sports and carried away red and blue vests and shorts, training T-shirts and track pants, and those godawful, stinking socks. He has dunked them in water, smothered them with soap, slapped them on a stone and tried to scrub the suffering out of them.

Sweat marks, dirt lines, mud stains, bits of grass, even spots of blood. When he has made the clothes clean again, Babbi has returned them, ironed and folded, smelling of freshness and optimism, so that their owners can climb into them and try again.

He has done this for years now but everytime a few men have reached for their wallets and said how much, Babbi has refused payment. Take it, they've said, don't be silly, it's your right. Babbi has smiled and said to them that he doesn't want the money, "*bas medal leke aana*" (Just bring a medal).

The washerman will have his wish. India's boxing team, for it is they who he so singles out, will return from Beijing with its first Olympic medal ever. It has taken a sustained assault to surmount a height previously considered insurmountable. India sent its biggest boxing contingent to scale their sport's Great Wall: the Olympics, a team of five young men, as tight as a



FINAL FRONTIER: (From left) Vijender after his quarter-final win, Jitender (in red) in action against Furkan Ulas of Turkey